16. Names and Numbers

‘After twenty-five years in cricket I’ve decided to move on. Cricket has given me everything I have. Thank you for being a part of this journey. This game taught me how to fight, how to fall, to dust off, to get up again and move forward. It has been a lovely journey. See you on the other side.’

With that message to his 4,650,000 Twitter followers, Yuvraj Singh announced his retirement from international cricket in early June 2019. In a flourish of which Bollywood would be proud, it was accompanied by a twenty-three-second, slow-motion video in which he turned his back to the camera, stroked the shoulder of his blue India shirt, number 12, and walked off, out of shot.

The greats of the Indian game, led by Virat Kohli, paid tribute. Yuvraj earned his immortality in 2011 by helping Sachin Tendulkar win his World Cup. He accumulated 362 runs in the tournament at an average of 90.50, took fifteen wickets and was named man of the match four times. That was the year he was diagnosed with lung cancer; his survival spawned a charity that has done untold good.

How should any of us be remembered? Yuvraj was a player of his time, a powerful left-handed middle-order batsman and left-arm spinner who excelled in white-ball cricket. Stuart Broad will probably not thank me for reminding you that Yuvraj hit him for six sixes in an over at the 2007 World T20, which India won. He played forty Tests, 304 one-day internationals and fifty-eight T20s.